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Purism and neologism in contemporary Maltese

Abstract

Il-puriżmu fil-Malti minn dejjem kien marbut mar-reġistru letterarju, speċjalment mal-poeżija. Mill-ewwel kantilena, miktuba madwar l-1470, sa l-1960, il-poeti u anki il-prożaturi letterarji kienu jippruvaw jużaw mill-inqas kliem ta' oriġini romanza. Imma fil-proża popolari, miktuba għad-divertiment tal-poplu, mingħajr ambizzjoni artistika, il-kliem romanz kien sistematikament ogħla u jirrifletti aħjar il-bilanċ fir-reġistru mitkellem. Anki l-iktar awturi prestiġjużi, bħal Dun KARM PSAILA u ĠUŻÉ AQUILINA, kienu jitilqu t-tendenzi puristiċi fil-proża xjentifika u fil-lessikografija (id-dizzjunarji). Mil-lat tal-kwantità, il-puriżmu ma jagħmilx sens illum, għax nafu li l-kliem ta' oriġini Għarbija fil-Malti, hekk kif jidher fid-dizzjunarju ta' AQUILINA, jasal sa 13,293 (32.41%) u dak mill-Isqalli u mit-Taljan jilħaq 21,481, tant li n-non semitiku (bil-Latin u bl-Ingliż) jitla' sa 24,705 (60.23%). Jolqotna l-fatt li, minkejja l-użu ta' l-Ingliż fl-iskejjel u fis-soċjetà, u l-ħafna taħlit (*code-switching*) li jsir fid-diskors informali, mhux iżjed minn 2511 kelma (6%) ssib postha fil-Malti standard. Dan għax il-kelliema huma konxji li l-kliem imħallat ġej mill-Ingliż, u ma jqisuhx bħala kliem Malti. Il-fattur tal-frekwenza jagħti ċifri differenti, għax il-kelmiet semitiċi jidhru iżjed spiss peress li jinkludu l-kliem grammatikali u l-kliem fondamentali.

1. Formal and informal situations

Purism necessarily implies reflection. It consists of a conscious attitude by the language user or by the language legislator to avoid language contact. It is therefore artificial and concerns the scholar rather than the average speaker. Consequently one has to distinguish between formal and informal usage, and not only between speech and writing but also between spontaneous and pondered speech. Obviously, in most cases speech tends to be much more spontaneous than writing, as GAETANO BERRUTO has shown in his sociolinguistic chart for contemporary Italian (1987: 21), but there are cases when speech moves closer to writing. On this point I agree with GIOVANNI NENCIONI (1983) who considers formal speech situations, like news bulletins and talks in front of audiences ("il parlato-scritto"), together with the dialogue of actors on stage or in films ("il parlato-recitato"), as texts that were first written then spoken, therefore essentially vocal reproductions of written models, read or memorized.

2. A literary choice

When we talk about purism we almost always have written registers in mind and it is not surprising, therefore, that one meets purism mostly in literary texts. The oldest surviving text in the Maltese language goes back to around 1470 and it has often been seen as proof that in the 15th century Maltese had experienced very little linguistic contact (WETTINGER & FSADNI 1968). It is true that in its 16 hendecasyllabic lines there is only one Romance word, *vintura*, but its position at the end of the line shows that it was unavoidable for two reasons, rhyme (with *sura*) and its preservation in the Maltese calque of a Sicilian proverb (BRINCAT 1999). Therefore it actually shows that the author of the Cantilena, PIETRO CAXARO, was evidently assuming a puristic stance. Were it not for the above reasons he would have avoided it, as he must have done for a number of Romance words. Actually most of the documents of local interest produced in Malta in the 15th century were written in a pan-Sicilian *koiné*, and the prevailing diglossia brought about strong linguistic contact in the capital and in the higher social domains. Indirect evidence of this lies in the many documents written in the Sicilian acrolect as early as 1409, which contain numerous words which have become part of the Maltese lexicon, often without a Semitic alternative. A second point is that the poem's topic (an allegorical lament against misfortune) only requires basic vocabulary, making it easy to avoid Romance terms.

This puristic attitude was followed by all the authors of verse in Maltese up to the 1950s and must have been a kind of linguistic scruple. One must keep in mind that from the 13th to the early 20th century all educated Maltese persons were bilingual because they only learned Latin (and perhaps Sicilian) up to the mid-16th century, Latin and Italian from 1530 till about 1830 and Italian and English up to the 1930s.[1] Their bilingual education made them perfectly conscious that Maltese was different from Italian, they felt that the use of Italian words in Maltese verse came too easily and therefore considered it a stylistic weakness. Purism remained a prime characteristic of Maltese poetry up to the 1960s and this fact negates the conclusion that the absence of Romance words in 17th, 18th, and 19th century poets reflected the unadulterated state of the local language.

In the early 19th century purism in poetry was a stylistic choice and was inspired by the Italian Romantics' penchant for *la parola peregrina*: a word was considered more beautiful if it was rare and archaic. Italian poets were the absolute models for Maltese

[1] Two thirds of the adult population still know Italian besides Maltese and English. See Table 3.

writers who automatically adapted the former's avoidance of *francesismi* to their own needs. It must also be stated that during that period Maltese authors were systematically building up Maltese literature in the vernacular, in an effort to create a standard variety that would raise the dialect to the status of a language. At that point in time the main criterion which distinguished languages from dialects was the existence of literary works.

3. A political issue

However, towards the middle of the 19th century purism became a political issue. The British authorities were feeling uncomfortable governing a colony where the official language was Italian. Moreover, the *Risorgimento* events had brought hundreds of Italian refugees to Malta and these were strengthening Italian culture and, by introducing the Romantic novel centred on local heroes and events, they were also fostering nationalistic ideals (FRIGGIERI 1986: 31-82). As early as 1813 the Secretary for the Colonies had written to the Governor of Malta recommending "the adoption of every means of substituting English for the Italian language" (despatch from LORD BATHURST to SIR THOMAS MAITLAND, 28th July 1813), but in those days English was unknown in the Mediterranean and all efforts proved fruitless. Within this context Protestant clergymen soon spoke out against the official use of Italian, possibly because they associated the language with the Roman Catholic Church which was blocking their penetration into Maltese society. In 1838 an Anglican scholar, the Rev. GEORGE BADGER, had expressed the opinion that Italian was only the language of the upper classes while the language of the people was an Arabic dialect. He therefore suggested that Arabic, not Italian, should be taught in the schools alongside English. This brought a very strong reaction and most Maltese clutched at the proverbial straw by reviving the notion that Maltese was derived from Punic, not from Arabic. This myth was considered an appeasing compromise by the authorities and their Maltese collaborators and they fostered it up to the 1950s because it associated the Maltese with a glorious ancient people and cut them off from both the northern and southern shores of the Mediterranean. According to an aberrant theory, it also brought the Maltese and the British nearer because LORD STRICKLAND, the most authoritative local imperialist who later became prime minister, picked up an idea from COL. L.A. WADDELL's book on *The Phoenician Origins of the Britons, Scots and Anglo-Saxons* and exploited it by stating that "The Phoenicians may

be called the English of the Old World", and that "The majority of the Maltese are of Phoenician origin and more akin to the British than to the Latins by race" (HULL 1993: 272-273).

4. Degrees of purism in different genres: from the lyrical to the practical domains

The Language Question was very hotly debated over almost a hundred years and, in spite of its largely unscientific principles, it did have a strong linguistic effect by consolidating the puristic tendency in literary works. The Royal Commission's recommendation that "the Maltese language should, as far as practicable, be purified by being brought nearer to the vocabulary and grammar of its parent Arabic" (KEENAN 1880, xxvi) was followed by most writers, whether one believed that Maltese was originally Punic or Arabic. This question was conveniently shelved by the choice of the umbrella term "Semitic". The first literary attempts responded to the need for creating simple works for the common folk, who were illiterate or barely literate, and since these works, consisting mainly of short religious or patriotic poems and humorous tales with a local rustic background, were restricted to the basic vocabulary, very little use was made of Sicilian and Italian terms.

In this way the Maltese language had come to be identified with the rustic variety, but even DUN KARM's ambitious philosophical poetry (from 1912 to 1961) and GUŻÉ AQUILINA's epic novel *Taħt Tliet Saltniet* (1935) kept the Romance words down to the barest minimum. One must note, however, that these same authors, who are perhaps the two most prolific and most respected writers of Maltese, used all the necessary Romance words in their personal correspondence and especially in literary criticism. In fact a random sample in AQUILINA's scientific prose (1989: 12-13) shows that no less than 20% of the words are of Romance origin, which is very high, considering that they are all content words and that function words are almost all Semitic. The non-puristic attitude is most evident in their lexical studies. DUN KARM PSAILA consciously used rare semitic terms like "*għajr, nikta, ħajbura, fommha, lewn, sura, kwiekeb, għajjura, l-oqħna, matmura, reqħba, ħabar*",[2] which may be archaisms or pseudo-archaic neologisms, in a sonnet entitled *Univers ieħor*, in spite of the fact that their Romance or more common Semitic equivalents are more frequently used in everyday speech (*hlief,*

[2] Meaning 'except', 'a sad event', 'low misty clouds', 'her mouth', 'colour', 'form', 'stars', 'caring', 'the richest', 'nutrition', 'greed', 'news'.

dispjaċir, sħaba, ħalqha, kulur, forma, stilel, protettiva, l-iżjed sustanzjuż, nutriment, għira, aħbar). However, when he compiled his *English-Maltese dictionary* (PSAILA 1955) he registered all the loan-words that were in use. Likewise, JOSEPH AQUILINA, who produced the most scientific lexicon of Maltese (1987, 1990), on which I shall focus further on, pointed out that Romance words are certainly more numerous than those of Semitic origin.

It can be safely said that purism characterized mainly the efforts for high literary aspirations, because writings of a practical nature are replete with Romance words. Non literary writings include sermons (like those of IGNAZIO SAVERIO MIFSUD, 1739-1746, and FRANCESCO SAVERIO BALDACCHINO, 1828) and popular narrative, like the late Romantic and Gothic novels which were often translated from Italian. In both genres the author's main aim was to deliver his ideas in a straightforward manner, and it is significant that the use of Romance words was not considered as an obstacle to comprehension; on the contrary it was rare and obsolete Semitic words that were avoided. Serialized fiction was very popular in Malta in the last decades of the 19th and in the first half of the 20th century and the feuilletons were read out to an illiterate audience that listened in groups, and later on the radio. Authors who had purely commercial interests showed no linguistic scruples and therefore shunned purism because they did not want to tax their readers. Three dissertations carried out under my guidance prove this point. MARY ANNE AGIUS (1994) compared the lexical content of a novel by CAROLINA INVERNIZIO (*Il bacio di una morta*, 1889) with its Maltese version by GIUSEPPE CUMBO (*Id-delitti tal-miġnuna*, 1934) and discovered that out of 849 Italian words which are used in Maltese (as entered in AQUILINA's dictionary), CUMBO adopted no less than 610, translated 93 with a different Italian word and only substituted 146 with their Semitic equivalents, giving an average of about 12 Romance words per page. As CUMBO was one of the most prolific of such authors between 1901 and 1935, he may be considered typical of this genre. MICHAEL GATT (1990) compared two Maltese versions of the same Italian novel (written in Malta) with the original to find out any differences over a lapse of time. MICHELANGELO BOTTARI had written his *Giammaria, ovvero l'ultimo dei baroni Cassia* in 1857, ANTONIO MUSCAT FENECH produced a Maltese version in 1890 and there was an anonymous abridged version in 1923. GATT analysed 1,080 Italian words which were adopted in the Maltese versions and concluded that although the older translation did not appear as semitizing, the more recent one used more Romance words and was apparently a linguistically updated version.

On the other hand, JOSEPH CHIRCOP (1990) analyzed two translations of a highly-rated Italian novel, *Le mie prigioni* by SILVIO PELLICO (1832) and found that both translators, despite the interval of 50 years, semiticized systematically. In fact ALFONS MARIA GALEA (1914) and VALENTIN BARBARA (1961) rejected 1088 out of 1398 Italian words (78%) which could be adopted from the original and only accepted 310. Their puristic preoccupation forced substantial stylistic constraints on them, because their rejection of basic and irreplaceable Romance words brought about semantic imprecision like *qaddis* ('saint') for *angelo* (avoiding *anġlu*), *djar* ('houses') for *palazzi (palazzi)*, *dinja* ('world') for *società (soċjetà)*, *ħiltek* ('your skill') for *coraggio (kuraġġ)*, *jifhem* ('he understands') for *immaginare (immaġina)*, *biża'* ('fear') for *scrupolo (skruplu)*, *kbar* ('great, large') for *preziosi (prezzjużi)*, and so on. It also had morphological and syntactic consequences because the lack of equivalent Semitic words caused changes in category, and therefore sentence structure had to be modified: *jitilquni* ('they leave me') for *libertà, kellimni* ('he spoke to me') for *riflessjoni, iħobbni* ('he loves me') for *simpatija, jaqtgħuhielek* ('they decide for you') for *sentenza* ('sentence', legal) Expression becomes heavy going because of rare and obsolete words, like *imherwlin* and *mirgħuna* for *irrabjati* (<arrabbiati), *ħamla* for *kurrent* (<corrente), *wirk* for *koxxa* (<coscia), *tnegħir* for *kritika* (<critica), *dgħul* for *dubju* (<dubbio), *kirfejh* for *spallejh* (<spalle), *minnugħ* for *bla permess* ('vietato'), while the substitution of single words by periphrases lengthens the sentence unnecessarily: *adulti* becomes *rġiel u nisa magħmulin* ('grown up men and women'), *ingiustizia* becomes *nuqqas ta' ħaqq* ('lack of justice'), etc. Both authors turn to periphrases in 385 out of 1398 cases. Semantic differences and nuances are lost when *carceriere, soldato, guardia, sgherro, attuario* and *brigadiere* all become *għassa* ('guard') and *pericolo, scrupolo, terrore, fatale* all become *biża'* ('fear'). On the other hand the avoidance of the irreplaceable word *virtù* makes the authors search for various renderings: *tieba, sedqa fir-ruħ, ħila* ('skill') *sbuħija* ('beauty'), *tajjeb* ('good'), *tieba* ('goodness'), *tjubija* ('goodness'), *virtù* ('virtue'), *drawwiet tajba* ('good habits'), *il-ħajja t-tajba* ('a good life'), *il-ħajja tar-ruħ* ('the soul's life', 'spiritual life'), *il-ħila li żżomm ir-ruħ fil-qies* ('the ability to keep the soul within limits'). Although both authors exploit the puristic attitude, GALEA (1914) was *engagé*, because he was one of the main exponents of the anti-Italian movement, while BARBARA (1961) was simply following what had become a literary tradition. It is almost as if they were trying to restore the language to a former hypothetically "pure" state.

The principal danger of purism was the impoverishment of the Maltese language, reducing it to a medium of expression which could only satisfy a rural community's basic needs. Had this happened it would have certainly been abandoned, since it could not have kept pace with social developments. The community would have therefore felt the need to seriously consider either BADGER's proposal of adopting the Arabic language or else embrace English exclusively. The former solution was inconceivable to the Maltese who were deeply Catholic and Southern European in high and folk culture, while the second one was obviously the long-term linguistic plan of the Imperial authorities, who must have had Wales, Scotland and Ireland in mind. *Malti safi* could never have satisfied the practical needs of a growing community, in spite of the beauty of its poetry, and its limitations were indirectly and unwittingly exposed by one of its main supporters, ANNETTO E. CARUANA, who produced a dictionary which only admitted words of Semitic origin (*Vocabolario della Lingua Maltese*, Malta, 1903) and in so doing drastically reduced the ideal vocabulary of Maltese. In fact CARUANA's dictionary registered only 9,947 words, when VASSALLI's (1796), a hundred years before (and he was no Italophile) listed 18,000.

5. Linguistic stratigraphy

The Maltese language had developed in a lively multilingual context. For over 800 years the variety of Arabic used in Malta, which now credibly appears to be the only survivor of Sicilian Arabic (AGIUS 1996), developed in complete isolation from the original offshoot and from Classical Arabic, which in all Arabic-speaking countries is the acrolect that serves as a unifying point of reference and keeps innovation in check. This was due to Malta's being ruled from Sicily and to its professing the Catholic faith, two facts which introduced Romance acrolects with the result that the local tongue nourished itself through its contacts with Sicilian, Italian and more recently English. Table 1 illustrates the stratigraphy of the Maltese language and, for the purposes of this study, I shall only point out that (1) there is apparently no substratum; (2) the basic stratum is Semitic and consists of the fundamental lexicon and most morphological features; (3) the Sicilian superstratum is still productive in adapting all Italian words to Sicilian vocalization patterns and to a few consonantal correspondences, especially those crystallized in suffixes and in certain verbal prefixes; (4) the Italian stratum is still open-ended, for contact is still strong though passive, mainly through television

(BRINCAT 1998); (5) contact with English is very strong, mainly through the schools and the media, but its Romance element is adapted to the Siculo-Italian patterns and consolidates the underlying strata, while the Germanic element creates difficulties in pronunciation and spelling.

Strata	Period	Languages	Words
adstratum 2	1800-	English	2,511 =06.12%
adstratum 1	1530-	Italian	21,481 =52.46%
superstratum	(1091)-1184-1900c.	Sicilian	
principal level	(870?)- 1048-1241	(Siculo) Arabic	13,293 =32.41%
substratum	535-870 218 BC-476 AD 650 BC-50 BC	Byzantine Latin Punic	nil =00% nil nil

Table 1: Linguistic stratigraphy

In consideration of the fact that purism essentially concerns the lexicon, I shall now take this opportunity to update the conclusions of my research on the lexical structure of the Maltese language, based on the etymology of the words included by JOSEPH AQUILINA in his *Maltese-English dictionary* in two volumes (1987-1990). I had presented the results of my preliminary study in an article for REINHOLDT KONTZI's festschrift (BRINCAT 1996) but the particular format of the dictionary had left almost 5000 words unaccounted for. I have now repeated the exercise with a different strategy and I am confident that the following table is much more accurate.

Total number of words:	41,016	100.00%
Semitic: Arabic	13,293	32.41%
Romance: Sicilian	1,746	04.26%
Italian	19,735	48.12%
other Italian dialects	38	
Latin	191	
French	215	
English	2,511	06.12%
various origins	269	
unknown origin	1,527	03.72%
local formations	1,491	01.73%
(mixed formations S/R, R/S)	(1,425)	
(obsolete)	(657)	
(names: toponyms, personal, nations)	(853)	
Total Semitic words	13,293	32.41%
Total non-Semitic (Sic., It., Lat., Fr., Eng., various)	24,705	60.23%
local and mixed formations	1,491	01.73%
unknown origin	1,527	03.72%
TOTAL	**41,016**	**100.00%**

Table 2: The components of the Maltese lexicon

The etymological analysis is based on J. AQUILINA (1987-1990). The words counted here are the headwords and all related entries shown in capital letters. This criterion thus excludes cross-references (registered in lower-case bold letters).

While the definition of the Maltese language remains basically Semitic, areally of the Western (Maghreb) type and historically closely linked with Sicilian Arabic, the composite nature of the Maltese lexicon makes it rather difficult to speak of purism. A puristic attitude nowadays would be absolutely impossible because the Semitic and the Romance elements have become fully integrated. Their complementary nature can be clearly illustrated by referring to the fact that the word for 'mother' is semitic, *omm*, while 'father' is Sicilian, *missier*; that the basic colours are Semitic (*abjad, iswed, aħdar, aħmar, isfar, ikħal, iżraq*) while the hues and shades are Romance (*blu, ċelesti, roża, griż, kannella, vjola, lelà, orangò, akkwamarìn*, as well as the qualifiers *skur, ċar*);[3] and the days of the week are Semitic (*it-Tnejn, it-Tlieta, l-Erbgħa, il-Ħamis, il-Ġimgħa, is-Sibt, il-Ħadd*, 'Monday to Sunday'), but the names of the months are Romance (*Jannar, Frar, Marzu, April, Mejju, Ġunju, Lulju, Awissu, Settembru, Ottubru, Novembru, Diċembru*).

[3] The Semitic colours are, in the above order: white, black, green, red, yellow, (greenish) blue, sky blue /azure. The Romance colours are: blue, light blue, pink, grey, brown, violet, lilac, orange, aquamarine. The qualifiers are: dark, light.

From a strictly numerical point of view AQUILINA's dictionary shows that the non-Semitic element adds up to 24,705 words out of 41,016. This is just over 60%. The Semitic element, consisting almost exclusively of dialectal Arabic terms, provides 13,293 words (32.41%). Of course, according to linguistic statistics, the latter should be more than enough for the average speaker's competence, which ranges between 5,000 and 7,000 words but, despite the easily recognizable division between fundamental and advanced words and their respective etymology, the one Semitic, the other Romance, the distinction is not always clear-cut. The impossibility of doing away with the Romance element becomes evident when one considers that certain Romance letters are very well represented by entries in AQUILINA's dictionary. In fact there are 1800 words starting with A, 1207 with E, 1179 with I, 579 with O, 204 with U, 820 with Ċ, 2737 with P, and 590 with V, while in the letters D, G, K, M, S, and T Romance entries heavily outnumber Semitic entries. Obviously, entries under the letters Għ, H, Ħ, Q, W, X, and Ż are exclusively or heavily Semitic.

The importance of the non-Semitic element in the Maltese lexicon is also shown in the basic vocabulary. Although presently there is no frequency word-list of Maltese we can have a look at two fundamental word-lists. First of all, in the Maltese version of SWADESH and LEES' one-hundred word-list we find only six Italian terms, and this was to be expected considering the etymological difference between basic and advanced lexemes (BRINCAT 2000: 190-191 shows that 65 of the terms in the Italian version of the same word-list provide derivatives which are used in Maltese). However in the word-list given by MIFSUD & BORG in Appendix C of their "communicative description of the Maltese language modelled on the Council of Europe's Threshold Level" (1997: 170-189), out of 1601 words 748 are Semitic, 641 are Romance and 196 are English. This means that the difference is already narrow in the basic communicative register, because the non-Semitic element here is not less than 52.28%, despite the fact that the list possibly includes all the function words.

6. English

Since the 1930s, English has replaced Italian as an official language and as a medium of instruction in the schools, and its use has multiplied in the entertainment field and on the job. The old colonial language has become the major world language, and nobody in Malta dreams of resisting it any more. However in AQUILINA's dictionary it is only represented by 2511 entries, just 6.12% of the total. This is even more surprising when one realizes that these entries contain a good number of maritime terms, associated with the presence of the Royal Navy, or with objects which have gone out of fashion, such as *gladstone bag, gold heater's skin, fore 'n aft, jock engine, drugget, cribbage, mudhole, magilp*. These words may be considered obsolete nowadays and their elimination would further reduce the percentage of English words in the Maltese lexicon. However younger people would favour the introduction of a number of new terms.

The reason that comparatively very few English words are considered as Maltese words lies in the fact that, first of all very few are indispensable and cannot be substituted by traditional lexemes. Here I am referring to terms such as *strike, truck, shock, van, jam*, etc. These have become naturalized and when they are used the speaker does not think of them as English words. Others, of Latin or French origin, have been naturalized in the usual Romance patterns (*irrealizza, evalwat, involuti* < to realize, evaluated, involved). However the great majority of English words that are used in Maltese are still perceived as English words and, while the naturalized terms are written phonetically (*strajk, trakk, xokk, vann, ġamm*, etc.; meanings quoted above), most readers resent the spelling of English words according to the Maltese alphabet (*ajrix, aptudejt, egżost, diżil, ħiter, ġerżi, droinrum, kuker*). Nowadays most Maltese people are bilingual and they are used to read and write "Irish, up-to-date, exhaust, diesel, heater, jersey, drawing-room, cooker". Undeniably, the public at large finds the Maltese phonetic rendering of English words irritating and unrecognizable and this practice does create problems for their adoption into the Standard variety. For instance *dramm* for *drum* 'container' clashes with *dramm* for 'play' (< It. *dramma*); *brejk* for *brake* ('stop') clashes with *brejk* for *break*, 'interval', *sejf* for *safe* 'unharmed' clashes with *sejf* (< Ar.) for 'sword'; *feri* is a homograph for 'ferry', 'fairy' and the imperative of the verb *fera* (from It. *ferire*) without rendering the real pronunciation of the first vowel, which is different in each case (closed/open, short/long, accented/unaccented). The drastic differences between the Maltese and the English vowel systems do not allow an adequate graphic rendering, despite the fact that in Maltese-English the complicated English vowel system is simplified to the basic five of the Sicilian system. This difficulty also concerns the accents, because English words often place the accent on the first syllable while Maltese prefers it on the last: *masil* for *muscle* could be read as [mas:il] by analogy with *barmil* and so would *tanil, nipil, padil* and *dabil* for *tunnel, nipple, puddle* and *double*. This could be corrected by introducing accents on the first vowels, but Maltese

spelling only uses accents for a few Italian words that require it on the last vowel (*virtù, pjetà, kwalità* < *virtù, pietà, qualità*). In spite of these difficulties AQUILINA decided on a blanket solution and this system seems to find favour with a number of authoritative linguists and especially with amateurs who consider it a form of revanchist move, a sort of nationalistic compensation: "we have to use English words but we write them our own way". However MIFSUD & BORG (1997) in the Maltese version of the CoE Threshold Level, carefully explain their reasons on pp. 4-5, and then in the word index, Appendix C, they prudently add the English spelling after the Maltese.

Is spelling English words the Maltese way a form of purism? Why are Italian words adapted and fully accepted in dictionaries and in writing, while English words that are used more frequently in everyday speech do not appear in dictionaries and on the written page? Even the more receptive MIFSUD & BORG (1997), whose word-list reflects usage in the 1990's, only admit 12.24% English words and 12.13% overall words and phrases. In fact while poetry since the Sixties began to admit words of Italian origin, there are still no writers who use English words in their literary efforts, although journalistic Maltese does admit a limited amount (4.74%, FENECH 1978). There are important differences which may explain the different attitudes.

First of all there is the factor of time. The Romance element penetrated into Maltese over a period of 800 years while English was introduced about 100 years ago. Another important factor is the mode of penetration. Sicilian and Italian words were passed on naturally from a minority of educated persons to an illiterate mass, and filtered in slowly and almost imperceptibly. In 1842 only 12,000 people knew Italian, 11% of the population, and in the previous centuries the percentage must have been even lower. Was it a coincidence that Italian words were freely admitted into poetry in the 1960s, when Italian was no longer felt as a threat to the survival of Maltese?

English only reached 10% of the population in 1901 and overtook Italian in 1911. However from 1931 to 1995 the number of persons knowing English rose from 54,600 to 246,157. This was due to its encouragement in the schools, and of course the turning point came in 1946 when primary school became compulsory for all the island's children and consequently English was taught systematically to the whole population. Since 1970, when secondary education became compulsory, it is being taught for five more years and in a wider context, because it is the medium of instruction for most school subjects since most textbooks are in English. At University exposure is even stronger

and reaches a wider audience: the number of students rose from 559 in 1968 to 7,322 in the year 2000.

The result of the widespread use of English at school and in society (see Table 3) is that a lot of code-switching and code-mixing is resorted to. During school lessons Maltese and English words are used in almost equal percentages, 48.2 and 51.8 respectively, while sentences and phrases are 40% in Maltese, 38% in English and 21.5% mixed (CAMILLERI 1995). In 1993 and 1996 two surveys among 500 adults and 930 schoolchildren aged 7 revealed that the use of English and the mixing of Maltese and English are on the increase (see Table 4; SCIRIHA 1997) but another survey held among 500 adults in 2000 established that only 1.2 % claim English to be their only native language, and 98.6% claimed Maltese as their native language. However 90% use it at home and 70% use it at work, while only 48% read in Maltese and a minimal 13.8% write it. On the other hand no less than 70.8% claimed proficiency in English but only 7.8% use it in the family (SCIRIHA & VASSALLO 2001: 6). Considering that Italian is known to 118,213 persons (36.4% of the population), and that it is used more than English only when watching television (which is passive), the stratigraphy of the Maltese language and the very low frequency of English words in the written medium do not reflect the large-scale use of English in present-day Malta. This must be due to the strict distinction that Maltese persons automatically make between the two languages on the written-spoken axis. While abundant use of English words and phrases is made during informal speech, when apparently every English word is potentially adoptable, and morphologically adaptable, into Maltese structures, there is a strong collective awareness that standard Maltese is different and has to be protected in writing and in formal speech, including the media. In the meantime, on the pragmatic level, the vocabularies of Italian and English stand by, as huge reservoirs for innovation. The average dictionaries, like COLLINS & ZINGARELLI contain over 100,000 entries, but there is no danger of these swamping the Maltese standard vocabulary (currently standing at 40,000) so long as they are used judiciously.

Population	324,386		
Maltese	317,311	German	6,807
English	246,157	Arabic	5,955
Italian	118,213	Spanish	1,955
French	31,945	other languages	3,365

Table 3: The knowledge of languages in Malta (1995 census)

Language spoken		Maltese %	English %	M+E mix %
At home:	between adults	90.4	1.0	6.8
	adults to children	76.6	2.6	15.4
	children to children	73.7	4.6	14.0
At home:	children to father	61.7	22.6	14.4
	children to mother	57.2	24.1	18.0
	among brothers & sisters	53.9	23.2	8.6
At school:	pupils to teachers	36.2	32.3	30.8
	among pupils	57.6	26.9	14.6

Table 4: Languages spoken in Malta

Maltese script

ċ voiceless alveopalatal affricate

ġ voiced alveopalatal affricate

ħ voiceless pharyngeal fricative

j palatal semiconsonant

w bilabial semiconsonant

x voiceless alveopalatal fricative

ż voiced alveolar fricative

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